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Clockwise from left: Haerin, Hyein, Hanni, Minji and Danielle of **NewJeans**, 2024's Group of the Year.

FEATURING

Charli XCX
Ice Spice
Karol G
Kylie Minogue
Maren Morris
NewJeans
PinkPantheress
Tems
Victoria Monét
Young Miko

EXECUTIVE OF THE YEAR
MICHELLE JUBELIRER

Women In Music

ABOUT

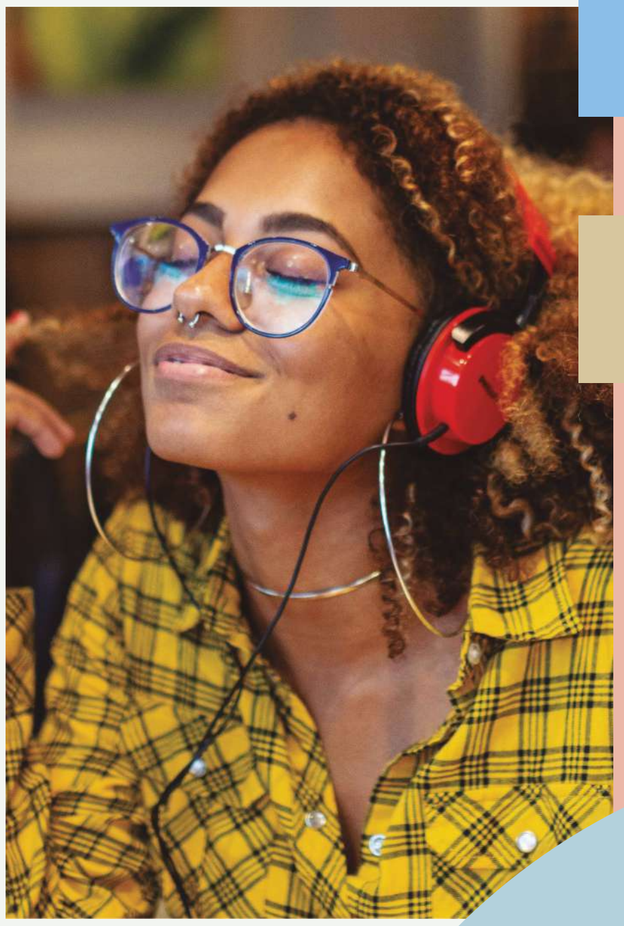
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Congratulations to our 2024 *Billboard* Women in Music honorees.

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Clockwise from left: NewJeans' Haerin, Hyein, Hanni, Minji and Danielle photographed by Ssam Kim on Dec. 4, 2023, at Seongbuk Songjae in Seoul.

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Victoria Monét photographed by Sami Drasin on Jan. 16 at Cricket Ranch in Los Angeles.

Oude Waag dress and Paumé Los Angeles earrings.

TO OUR READERS
Billboard will publish its next issue on March 9. For 24/7 music coverage, go to billboard.com.

MASON POOLE

charts

DATA FOR WEEK OF 3.02.2024



BILLBOARD HOT 100

1
"Texas Hold 'Em"
Beyoncé

LAST WEEK	PEAK POSITION	WEEKS ON CHART
2	1	2

'Texas Hold 'Em' Deals Beyoncé Winning Hand

BEYONCÉ'S **"TEXAS HOLD 'EM"** shuffles to No. 1 on the Billboard Hot 100. The superstar earns her ninth leader on the list and her first since "Break My Soul" in 2022.

A week earlier, the banjo-inflected single became the Houston native's historic first No. 1 on the multimetric Hot Country Songs chart, as she became the first Black woman to lead the list. The track adds a second week at the summit on charts dated March 2.

The single is one of two that Beyoncé released Feb. 11, along with "16 Carriages." Their arrival was announced in a Verizon commercial that aired during CBS' broadcast of Super Bowl LVIII, ahead of the March 29 release of her new album, which follows her 2022 *Renaissance* set.

"Texas Hold 'Em" drew 29 million official streams (up 51%) and 16.1 million in radio airplay audience (up 233%) and sold 29,000 downloads (down 25%) in the United States Feb. 16-22, according to Luminate.

The song is also Beyoncé's first entry on the Country Airplay chart, surging 54-34 this week (2.8 million impressions at the format, up 156%). It also jumps 38-25 on Mainstream Top 40 and debuts at No. 28 on Adult Top 40 and Adult R&B Airplay, No. 36 on Rhythmic Airplay and R&B/Hip-Hop Airplay and No. 40 on Mainstream R&B/Hip-Hop Airplay.

"We put ["Texas Hold 'Em"] directly into a strong rotation. I want the station to sound as interesting as possible because the opposite is boring," says Dave Parker, program director of Sinclair's country-formatted WUSH Norfolk, Va. "This song is sounding great and doesn't sound like anything else."

—GARY TRUST AND JIM ASKER

GROUP OF THE YEAR

NewJeans

BY PAUL THOMPSON

PHOTOGRAPHED BY SSAM KIM

From left: NewJeans' Haerin, Hyein, Minji, Danielle and Hanni photographed Dec. 4, 2023, at Seongbuk Songjae in Seoul
Shushu/Tong clothing



Haerin (left) and Hyein



STYLING: PUROM LEE. JI EUN PARK. SEO YUN CHOI AND YU JIN KIM. HAIR: HYE JIN LEE. DA YE YANG AND JI IN KIM. MAKEUP: DOL LEE AND KYUNG MIN LEE. PRODUCTION: STACY NAM.

"We didn't really think, 'Oh, we're going to change music, that's crazy.' We just wanted to try something new and fun."

—DANIELLE

AS THE FIVE MEMBERS of NewJeans file gracefully down the stairs at their *Billboard* photo shoot in Seoul, they greet me with bright smiles and genuine greetings of "Nice to meet you." Just a few days prior, the exploding K-pop girl group won artist of the year and song of the year at both the Melon Music Awards and MAMA Awards, two of South Korea's most prestigious music prizes — and just two of the roughly 10 awards shows they attended and performed at in the country this past December and early January. Yet despite the hectic schedule of winter awards season there, they exude warmth and enthusiasm.

That infectious energy has endeared the women of NewJeans — Minji, Hanni, Danielle, Haerin and Hyein, who range in age from 16 to 19 — to fans both in South Korea and worldwide. Since debuting in July 2022, NewJeans has swiftly ascended to the top of the K-pop pantheon. Six of its eight released singles have reached No. 1 or No. 2 on South Korea's dominant streaming measure, the Circle Digital Chart. The act has made inroads on several *Billboard* charts as well, including three top 10 hits on the Global 200 and four on the Global Excl. U.S. chart, five entries on the Billboard Hot 100 and six top 10s on World Digital Song Sales (the highest-reaching was "Super Shy," peaking at No. 2 last July). The group's songs have gained 931.6 million official U.S. on-demand streams, according to Luminate.

Along the way, NewJeans has smashed expectations in K-pop, helping lead a new era of female influence in a genre long dominated by male groups. While it was once accepted industry wisdom that only boy bands could build a core fandom *and* widespread commercial success (selling both albums and concert tickets), NewJeans is part of a girl-group generation that has done both, shifting the paradigm of what achievement entails for young female groups. And NewJeans has done so under the guidance of an equally innovative leader: It's the first act to debut under ADOR (All Doors One Room), led by founder and CEO Min Hee Jin, the rare woman leading a K-pop label and management company.



"I want our songs to move people. My goal is not only to have songs that are emotional but also to share the emotions with people onstage and through our music."
—HAERIN



About a decade ago — when this writer started working in K-pop as a producer — it sounded very differently. Record labels emphasized melody, dynamic vocal range and cohesive track arrangements, while dance performance was simply considered support for a song. Over time, the music trended toward bombastic anthems well-suited to choreography, and so-called "easy listening" songs (those preferred by the South Korean general public, who of late have not been K-pop's core audience) tended to get lost. But NewJeans has proved that strong performances and easy listening need not be mutually exclusive. And as *Billboard*'s Group of the Year says in person in Seoul, the act is just getting started.

How did it feel to win artist of the year and song of the year at the Melon Music Awards and MAMA Awards?

HANNI It was really surreal to win such big awards. Honestly, for us, when it comes to these types of awards shows, we are just excited to be there. Just to be invited is an honor. We never expected [to win]. We really are just thankful for everyone who has put in a lot of hard work toward our content and music and all the people that really enjoyed it, so I think it just makes it more fun.

DANIELLE I agree with Hanni. There are so many people that put in so much effort and hard work into what we do, and we are just so honored that so many people are enjoying it just as much as we are enjoying it. Sharing that happiness and positive energy through our music is such an honor in itself.



You have a small discography but so many big songs like "Ditto," which won song of the year at the Melon and MAMA awards. Which did you expect to become as big as they did?

DANIELLE When our CEO has a new song and she's prepared to make a new album, she gets us all in her studio and we listen to all the songs together. I remember the first time we heard the songs for our album *Get Up*, we were just blown away. Because we truly were just like, "This is so us! This is so NewJeans." When I first heard "Ditto," I felt a connection to it — I guess I felt if people hear this, I want them to feel they're healed in some way. So to know that people out there are receiving somewhat of a positive energy, it's really amazing. Every time we release new music, we wonder if people are going to enjoy it just as much as we do. To see people out there jamming to our songs, it puts a really big smile on our faces.

Traditionally, men have run the K-pop industry, and ADOR was notably founded by a woman. What was it like training under a CEO who has that shared perspective?

DANIELLE I can't imagine what it would be like if it wasn't for our CEO, Min Hee Jin. We are so close to her, and we feel such

a strong connection to her. After a conversation with her, we'd just be inspired and learn so much When we go overseas and stuff, she'd take us out shopping and we'd have dinner together, and we'd spend hours and hours laughing and talking about what happened and how we've been and telling stories.

HYEIN She is very consistent. She's always wondering about us and worrying about us. She's very friendly and reaches out [to us] first, which helps us feel really comfortable around her. She gives us advice like a mother would. She's not just a great CEO but a great human being in general.

Historically, core fandoms have been harder for women to achieve in K-pop. But in the last few years that has completely changed, and NewJeans is at the forefront of that. Why do you think you've been able to capture that?

MINJI It may have to do with the fact that the K-pop market became a lot bigger. That's one of the reasons why we started with so much attention and love from the general public. We never really set a specific [goal], but rather aimed to put on a performance that we love with songs that we love. I think this probably helped our fans love us from early on.

HAERIN I agree with Minji. I think it's also because there are so many channels we can use to communicate with our fans and the public.

I think NewJeans has changed how music sounds in K-pop, with a trend toward returning to easy listening music. Do you agree?

DANIELLE Music itself is always changing. But before we debuted, our CEO told us that she wanted to do something new, something fresh and different. But with that, she wanted it to be, no matter who you are, no matter what age or gender, you can listen to it and enjoy it. So I think with that came the easy listening music. We didn't really think, "Oh, we're going to change music, that's crazy." (*All laugh.*) We just wanted to try something new and fun.

You've accomplished so much in a short time. Where do you want to go from here?

HAERIN I want our songs to move people. My goal is not only to have songs that are emotional but also to share the emotions with people onstage and through our music.

MINJI I have similar thoughts to Haerin, but I want our music to be remembered for a long time. For example, I want people to think of last winter when they hear "Ditto."

DANIELLE Besides music and performing, I just want to become someone who stays true to myself and is always open-hearted and open-minded and modest and tries really hard because there are so many things I want to do and so many places I want to go. I want to experience a lot and learn a lot and just enjoy the time being with the [NewJeans] members.

From left: Minji, Danielle, Haerin, Hanni and Hyein.



WOMAN OF THE YEAR

Karol G

BY LEILA COBO PHOTOGRAPHED BY VIJAT MOHINDRA

HI, EVERYBODY. MY NAME IS KAROL G. I am from Medellín, Colombia. This is my first time at the Grammys, and this is my first time holding my own Grammy."

To her tens of millions of fans and followers (68.2 million on Instagram alone) watching February's Grammys telecast, that humble introduction from the winner of this year's award for best música urbana album wasn't surprising — Karol G's openness and honesty, along with the personal nature of her music, are a big part of what has endeared her to so many. Still, the award felt a bit superfluous.

At 33, Karol G just wrapped an extraordinary year in which she became the first woman (and second artist ever) to top the Billboard 200 with an all-Spanish-language album (*Mañana Será Bonito*, for which she won that Grammy); the top female Latin artist on *Billboard*'s year-end charts (behind only Bad Bunny and Peso Pluma); and the winner of album of the year at November's Latin Grammys, as well as urban album of the year — the first woman to win the latter.

Karol is also the first Latina (and still one of only a few women) to headline a global stadium tour and the highest-grossing Latin touring artist of 2023 by far: According to Billboard Boxscore, she grossed $155.3 million and sold 925,000 tickets from 20 shows, placing at No. 11 on *Billboard*'s all-genre year-end Top Tours chart. The only women who fared better on the list were Beyoncé and P!nk, who played 55 and 37 shows, respect vely. (Taylor Swift did not report her 2023 touring numbers.)

And yet the artist born Carolina Giraldo still feels she has something to prove. "I'm certain many people still don't know me and don't know what I've done," she says. So at the Grammys, "I wanted to make it clear, because I have so many projects planned, that I want them to know I'm working to accomplish far bigger things."

And as *Billboard*'s Woman of the Year — the first artist who records only in Spanish to receive the honor — Karol says she's even more motivated to maintain her stunning upward trajectory. "It's so meaningful and inspiring to get an award that's not only 'woman of this or that category' but 'Woman of the Year.' I feel a huge responsibility to make the year on par with the title," she says. (Karol's sister Jessica Giraldo, an attorney who co-manages her with Noah Assad and Raymond Acosta of Habibi Entertainment, is on *Billboard*'s executive list this year.)

Karol's journey to the top of the charts has been slow and steady over the past decade. But in 2022, it accelerated (and went beyond language barriers) with her $trip Love U.S. arena tour, which grossed $72.2 million and sold 424,000 tickets. That helped send *Mañana Será Bonito* to a No. 1 debut on the Billboard 200 in February 2023, which, in turn, led to her first stadium tour and the release of a second album, *Mañana Será Bonito* (*Bichota Season*), which debuted at No. 3 in August.

Since the very beginning of 2024, Karol says she has "literally made music every day," working with collaborators including longtime go-to producer Ovy on the Drums, who often meets up with her on the road and will be traveling with her during the Latin American leg of her tour. That kicked off Feb. 8 with the first of three sold-out dates at Mexico City's Estadio Azteca (80,000 seats per night, according to promoter OCESA). Karol will play 24 stadium dates in Latin America (most were already sold out at press time) before moving on to 16 arenas nnd stadiums in Europe, including three dates at Santiago Bernabéu Stadium in Madrid.

"The fact that she headlined predominantly theaters in 2021, then arenas in 2022, then jumped to stadiums in 2023 is unprecedented for any genre," Jbeau Lewis, Karol's touring agent and partner at UTA, told *Billboard* last year. "It's easy to talk about Karol as a leader in Latin music, but based on the success she has had, especially this year, she should be spoken about in the same breath as Taylor or Beyoncé."

Karol is acutely aware that as her global audience grows, the stakes for what she does next keep rising. "I started this year with a completely different mindset," she says. "Although this may sound like a beauty queen reply, the place I'm at right now is one of huge responsibility, and it demands that I'm very aware of what surrounds me so I don't make missteps."

To prepare, she took some time off over the winter holidays — an effort toward "working enormously on my mental state, black belt level," she says with a laugh. "I'm very clear about my plans, my vision of the future and the order in which I want to release [music] and express myself."

For a Colombian who grew up in Medellín in the aftermath of cartel leader Pablo Escobar's death, when the country was consumed by drug warfare, that sense of responsibility is especially personal and profound. "My father always told us: 'We have an obligation to give back — not what's left over but what's right,' " she says. That idea inspired her in 2021 to launch the Con Cora foundation, which supports women in vulnerable situations through actions in education and the arts.

"When I take the stage in a stadium, one of the reasons I cry is because I know one day this will all be over; I'll be home remembering the time I was No. 1," she says. "That's life. But what I will have is a school I built, or a project we launched [through the foundation]. Today, and in 10 years and in 50 years, lives will change thanks to something we built."

In the meantime, even as she tours, Karol is putting out singles and remains "very open to experimenting with new sounds," as is clear on "Contigo," her recently released song with Tiësto. "I'm feeling very proud because I'm working. I'm really rising to the challenge, and I have to push forward, push forward," she says. "I may be a very important Latin artist, but I still have the whole world ahead of me.



Karol G photographed Nov. 11, 2023, at Powder Room Studios in Los Angeles.

Styling by Marta del Rio
Tiffany Brown catsuit and jacket and Retrofête x Keren Wolf earrings.

HAIR BY CESAR DELEON RAMIREZ. MAKEUP BY PATRICK TA AT PARTNER. MANICURE BY DIOSSAKAURA AT A-FRAME AGENCY. SET DESIGN BY RAMON MICHEL TNN.

Young Miko photographed Sept. 11, 2023, in New York.

Styling by Storm Pablo

HAIR AND MAKEUP BY JONJEL MAZER

IMPACT

Young Miko

BY JESSICA ROIZ PHOTOGRAPHED BY LIA CLAY MILLER

YOUNG MIKO VIVIDLY REMEMBERS the first time she realized her music could make an impact. It was in 2021, after the Puerto Rican singer-rapper released her second single, "Vendetta," in collaboration with trans artist Villano Antillano — a hard-hitting trap song in which the two spit bars about empowerment, individuality, resilience and self-confidence, all while spotlighting the LGBTQ+ community.

"That's when I felt a before and after in my life," Miko tells *Billboard*. "It's a moment that I always return to, and I realize that it wasn't just a song. I feel in my heart that it started a very beautiful movement or gave it more strength. I love feeling that from the beginning I've been doing something good with the voice that life has given me and with the space I have, which has to have a purpose."

That same voice — one that effortlessly transitions from unapologetic rap rhymes to smooth, sugary vocals — and a devoted work ethic have propelled Miko to become one of *música urbana*'s brightest new stars, breaking through in the male-dominated genre while primarily singing about her queer identity.

The 25-year-old artist born María Victoria Ramírez de Arellano Cardona has landed major collaborations with Bad Bunny, Arcángel, Feid, Bizarrap and Karol G — most recently playing the latter's romantic interest in Karol's cinematic "Contigo" music video. She has also had a strong presence on the *Billboard* charts, including four hits on Hot Latin Songs and three on Latin Airplay, two entries on the Billboard Hot 100 and five on the Billboard Global 200 and Global Excl. U.S.

But even amid those successes, this year's Impact honoree says she's still learning. "It's important to have that mentality and to not think I'm at my peak," she says. "I want to feel like I'm never going to stop being a student, and for me, that's the coolest part."

How has embracing your queer identity in your lyrics affected your art?

It has been everything. My lyrics demonstrate a Young Miko that's 100% true to herself. Thank God, I've felt comfortable enough from the beginning to be able to do it and give myself that space to be myself and do what I want with my music. I think it's very nice that it had a good impact on the music industry in general and on the people around me. Obviously, sometimes, it can get loud — your surroundings, the opinions of others — but I feel like Young Miko would never have been the same if I wasn't 100% honest in my music.

How have you used your social media presence to create change around you?

Beyond a social media platform, I like to start with my circle and the people who are with me every day. In whatever way I can help, I will always try to add or contribute my grain of sand. Obviously, being aware that anything I publish or associate with will have an impact, period. I know that now people are listening and paying attention to what I say, which gives me more reason to want to promote a good message. There are so many people with so many followers, and they don't use it for shit. For me, it's a blessing that life has decided to put me in a spot where my voice matters.

You joined Karol G for her *Mañana Será Bonito* tour and headlined your own *Trap Kitty* tour last year. What effect did the touring life have on you?

I fucking love touring! It's so much fun. I feed off a lot from the crowd and the energy. Sometimes you have to see it to believe it — the emotion of all the people and how they know your songs. I learned that it's not always going to be pretty. There are days that are going to be super tiring, and if you cancel or postpone a show, it's horrible [for the fans] but you must get through it. Beyond learning as an artist, I learn as a person. When I'm on tour, I miss my home, my parents, my island, the warmth of my people. It's a roller coaster and not for the weak. It's so surreal, but I fucking love it.

ANDREA SWIFT

13 MANAGEMENT



Taylor Swift (left) accepted the Milestone Award from her mother, Andrea, at the Academy of Country Music Awards in 2015.

ROB KIM/WIREIMAGE

Andrea Swift has been with Taylor Swift since the beginning. The mother of the superstar claims no credit for her daughter's remarkable achievements — the culture-shaking presence onstage and in streams, the four Grammy Awards for album of the year, the 96.8 million in equivalent album units consumed by her fans — including album sales, track sales and streaming activity.

But seldom has an artist been so forthcoming about the importance of her mother as has Taylor — perhaps just one more reason she connects so deeply with her fans.

From early in her career, Taylor has raised the profile of Andrea, who, along with her father, Scott Swift, plays a key role in the singer's company, 13 Management.

Andrea is seen among the well-wishers at Taylor's 18th birthday party in the 2008 video contained on the EP Beautiful Eyes, and she is the centerpiece of Taylor's song and video "The Best Day" from Fearless, describing how her mother helped her ignore a snub from a high school clique.

In 2015, it was Andrea who presented her daughter with the Milestone Award for "unprecedented achievement" at the Academy of Country Music Awards. Through the years, Andrea has received producer credits on her daughter's videos and films, most recently on folklore: The Long Pond Sessions in 2020.

Taylor has shared her concerns on social media and in interviews when Andrea was diagnosed with breast cancer in 2015, a recurrence of that cancer in 2019 and a brain tumor in 2020.

And it is Andrea's mother, Taylor's maternal grandmother, a former opera singer, who inspired the song "Marjorie" on evermore. The song contains a lyric that goes to the heart of Taylor's incredible mix of emotional artistry and business savvy — a potent combination passed down from grandmother to mother to daughter. "Never be so kind you forget to be clever," she sings. "Never be so clever you forget to be kind." —THOM DUFFY

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